

Dating in Darkness

If you talk about experiences which made my life livelier – I had many. But when it came to dating, I was pretty a novice. So that night, walking beside K, under the canopy of green, yellow and red leaves; the mild breeze gently messing with her hair; and the sound of waves hitting the shore beyond the walls; all of it cohered to make it a lovely territory to dive in.

We were walking towards the Silver Jubilee campus. If Pondicherry University was Europe, Silver Jubilee was Paris; and Rome. Paris, because it was the abode of intimacy; as in you cannot stand there without having romance gushing through your nerves. And Rome, because it was not built in a day!

This Silver Jubilee, structurally, had two concentric circular highways running at a radius of around fifty and seventy-five metres. The inner one, sufficiently lit, encompassed a huge barren land. Between the inner and the outer were the neatly crafted academic buildings. And the outer circle, which was usually darker, was dedicated to higher levels of romantic manoeuvres.

And when we came to the point where we had to choose between the inner and the outer circle, I was quite tensed. Then K insisted upon taking the outer one. And that made me go insanely happy.

Being a novice all I knew was that my life was changing after this night; but I didn't know in what way. And quite naturally I began to wonder how to begin that procedure. How to break the ice of the hour. Thankfully it was she who initiated the conversation; in an extremely "romantic" manner!

So tell me, are you afraid of darkness?

Going back to the time when I first came to Pondicherry, I didn't really want to come out of it. Most of the North Indians who ended up in PU were driven largely by two incentives – the gorgeous beaches, and the cheap alcohol. But I was there because I loved the land – first in the pictures and then in reality. And I was just out of school. We were some two hundred undergraduates drowning in a sea of thousands of postgraduates like K. And settling yourself academically in such a scholarly atmosphere couldn't be easy at all. But it was. And we realised that only when we encountered the actual problem.

Most of the girls around were at least three years elder to us. And the pain of being universal "brothers" was unparalleled to any other.

But K was truly beautiful. Or precisely she was what guys like me with ugly faces would call way-out-of-my-league. Yet, it was the irony of life, that if you fast forwarded a good number of bus stop encounters, exchanged stares, exchanged phone numbers, double meaning chats, and exciting dreams – you would find me there beside K in the "outer" circle of Silver Jubilee.

I was afraid of darkness. So, I told her that I wasn't. And I wondered if talking about darkness was a conventional thing to do in a date. Actually, nothing happened which would comply with my popular

idea of a date. We just walked through the darkness. And to be honest it was dark enough to calm your hormones to some extent. And as we passed some way through the silent night, I asked her, hazarding all my wishes, if we could walk in towards the inner circle.

Let's sit here, she said, with an elderly tenor. As if she had infinite knowledge and experience with sitting. And I couldn't help but comply.

And we sat on the edge of the footpath. And we sat there for some time. I began to make efforts to ignite some conversation. And I asked about anything and everything that crossed my mind – hometown, hobbies, plans, random variables, programming languages, celestial bodies etc. But K was totally stingy with words. She used nothing more than a word or two. And not too late into it, I realised that I didn't turn out interesting enough!

But there was a lot of night still left.

And I kept my hopes of receiving a fair share of my expectations. I believed that my life was still going to change. I believed so, only until she motioned to cut me mid-sentence. And all she said was a creepily elongated *shhhhhhhh*.

The first blow of the night and it hurt. It hurt my usually non-existent ego. And it hurt me so much that I was compelled to make a call at whether to stay any further. Whether to embrace any further humiliation. But I eventually did because a part of me still hoped. And then...

Then she put an arm across my shoulder. So, all of a sudden blow-number-one was cancelled. A lot of good things begin by keeping arms around shoulders. And every little nerve ending in my body was a live wire. My heart synced to the rhythm of my favourite songs. The hope – it glimmered brighter than the sun in the opposite hemisphere. The world suddenly became a beautiful place. And my insides started to celebrate; because my life was about to change.

But although K continued to exist, her actions made me doubt my axioms; because, there was no action at all! As if she was my emotional inverse. While I was having a hard time holding my heart in its place, she sat there like a beautiful stone crafted with brilliant curves and weird glasses. And somewhere down the line the net sum of world enthusiasm remained constant.

It was getting terribly awkward. Every passing second killed a butterfly that tried to fly within my stomach. And I grew very impatient. Suddenly the weight of her arm began to bother me. Something felt wrong.

But I still hoped.

Let's move, I intently blurted out patting her back. What followed was unbelievable. K turned her head like dolls do in horror movies. And through my eyes, which by then had adjusted to the darkness, I could clearly make out her stern cold eyes staring at me; further enlarged by the powered glass.

Something terrible was surely on its way.

Don't you dare touch me. She said, and calmly turned away. And yes, she said that with *her* arm around *my* shoulder!

But she meant it; because her voice was low and her tone ominous.

This was the second blow of the night. And now I no longer hoped. I accepted the fact that the night was doomed; that my life was going to remain the same. The night, so far, had been a strange one. There was so much I had expected out of this date. Every step we took inside the outer circle had led to the discovery of new realms of fantasies. But all that was returned was humiliation. Cold, bare humiliation.

Life was sad.

I immediately got up and began pace away. I tried to keep calm. I didn't want to snap back at her and leave. But she was also my date. And as I slowly walked away through the darkness, the canopy of leaves, the breeze, and the sound of waves, I felt bad. And I paused; and then turned.

She was still there at the edge of the footpath. I chose to forget all the shame she had hurled at me. And then I hoped, for one last time.

I turned on the flash of my phone. I was about to ask if she wanted to come along. Seconds later, I was running as if my life depended on it. My knees ached for rest, my throat pleaded for water, and my lungs gasped for air. But I never stopped; not until I reached my room and sealed the door, and the windows, and the ventilators.

Later I came to know that K had hearing difficulties, along with several other instances of going berserk; some of them as serious as chasing a floor-mate with a paring knife. And stories such as these scared me to death.

K and I, we would still come across each other at bus stops, library, and reading halls. But I never dared to meet her eye. But that moment still remains fresh in my memory. And no matter how much I try to convince myself; that it was nothing more than an ideally executed prank; or the strangest example of absent mindedness; my throat still goes dry with the very thought of it.

My life was indeed changed. Never in my life was I going to date in darkness, if not *not* date at all.

Because on that night when I saw K through the cell-phone flash, she was still seated at the edge of the footpath; in the exact same manner as when I was there beside her; her right arm hanging mid air; resting against the shoulders of an invisible person.